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Volume XXXIII Number 30: For the week July 22-28, 2008, released on July 21

● Editorial Office: Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001. Phones: 23315801-4; Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi
● Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301; Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080; e-mail: weare@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-24444423-6; Fax: 24444358 ● Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi ● Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 ● Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Panel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 ● Hamilton House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 ● 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, 2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable: Livmedia Chennai ● 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore ● 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22825398; Fax: 22827254; Cable: Livmedia, Kolkata ● 6-3-885/7/8, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 ● 39/1045, Karakkatt Road, Kochi 682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058; Fax: 2377059 ● 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwadi, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293
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● INDIA TODAY does not take the responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material.

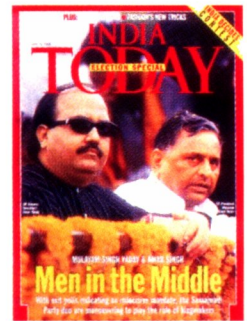
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If anyone ever doubted the oft-quoted adage that in politics, there are no permanent friends or enemies, only permanent interests, then they can have no better proof than what is happening in Indian politics today.

The UPA Government, abandoned by its allies on the Left over the nuclear deal, is struggling for its existence. It is scrambling to put together a majority for the trust vote in Parliament. Surprisingly, its saviour in this messy scenario happens to be a politician who was personally snubbed by Congress supremo Sonia Gandhi, making him a political pariah for the Government and consigning him to the outer fringes of national relevance for four years.

He is none other than the indomitable Amar Singh, the general secretary of the Samajwadi Party which has 37 MPs in the Lok Sabha. Singh is the quintessential dealmaker, the person who has good friends in all the right places, a smooth talker, a wily political strategist, a street fighter, a man whom people love and fear at the same time. Few politicians dine with movie stars, breakfast with the rustic Mulayam Singh Yadav in Etawa, rub shoulders with corporate bigwigs, adorn the society pages and turn up regularly on the nightly news.

In fact, if scientists were to design a politician ideally engineered to flourish in India's coalition politics, he would come in the form of Amar Singh. The situation he finds himself in today, through fortuitous circumstances, is made to order for him. A hapless Government is dependent on his skill of not only keeping his own flock together but also luring others to vote for the Government.



Our May 2004 cover

Amar Singh's fancy political footwork is evident in the way he has executed a deft somersault over his party's stand on the nuclear deal. Virulently against the deal initially, the SP is now for it on the pretext that their 'political and national interests' have had a happy convergence. The one thing Singh understands best is the dynamics of attaining and retaining power. If he is successful in delivering the numbers to the UPA Government, you can be sure he will claim a hefty pound of flesh from the Congress.

Our cover story on the craft of Amar Singh this week is written by Editor Prabhu Chawla, who spent considerable time with Singh as India counted down to the trust vote. Chawla, who has known Singh for more than two decades, says, "His friends and foes will tell you when he makes a promise, he keeps it."

This is Amar Singh's big moment; if he can live up to this latest promise, he will go down in history as the unlikely candidate who saved a Congress-led government and a historic deal. Should he fail and the Government fall within the week, he will end up as a political footnote. Although, I would not bet on it. He was dropped from our annual Power List in March this year. How wrong we were.

Aaron Purie

(Aron Purie)